

CULTURE AND LEARNING

From the poets, sculptors, and painters of the ancient world to the commentators and conceptual artists of the 21st century, the work of writers and artists provides an invaluable insight into the thoughts and aspirations of these the great civilizations of the past. In Europe, from the 11th century, and in the succeeding centuries on other continents, the talents of many of these people were nurtured in the universities that sprang up as conduits for the transmission of learning.

POETS, PLAYRIGHTS, AND NOVELISTS

Literature gives us a special insight into the past. Though the plots of novels and plays may be invented, the characters speak and behave in ways that reflect the preoccupations, social mores, and artistic conventions of their time, and in many works, a fictional chain of events plays out against a rich background of verifiable historical happenings.

NAME	LIVED	ORIGIN	GENRE	NOTABLE WORKS
Homer	8th century BCE	Ancient Greece	Poet	<i>Odyssey</i> [8th century BCE]
Aeschylus	c. 525–456 BCE	Ancient Greece	Playwright	<i>Seven Against Thebes</i> [c.467 BCE]
Sophocles	c. 496–406 BCE	Ancient Greece	Playwright	<i>Antigone</i> [c.442 BCE]
Euripides	c. 484–406 BCE	Ancient Greece	Playwright	<i>Medea</i> [c.431 BCE]
Aristophanes	c. 448–388 BCE	Ancient Greece	Playwright	<i>The Frogs</i> [c.405 BCE]
Valmiki	c. 400–200 BCE	Ancient India	Poet	<i>Ramayana</i> (c.400–200 BCE)
Virgil	70–19 BCE	Roman Empire	Poet	<i>Aeneid</i> [c.29–19 BCE]
Ovid	43 BCE–c.17 CE	Roman Empire	Poet	<i>Metamorphoses</i> [8 CE]
Murasaki Shikibu	c. 978–1014	Japan	Novelist	<i>The Tale of Genji</i> [c.1001–10]
Dante Alighieri	1265–1321	Italy	Poet	<i>Divine Comedy</i> [c.1321]
Petrarch	1304–74	Italy	Poet	<i>Canzoniere</i> [1327–68]
Geoffrey Chaucer	1343–1400	England	Poet	<i>The Canterbury Tales</i> [1387–1400]
Miguel de Cervantes	1547–1616	Spain	Novelist/ poet/ playwright	<i>Don Quixote</i> [1605]
William Shakespeare	1564–1616	England	Playwright/ poet	<i>Romeo and Juliet</i> [c.1591–95]
John Milton	1608–74	England	Poet	<i>Paradise Lost</i> [1667]
Molière	1622–73	France	Playwright	<i>Le Misanthrope</i> [1666]
Jean Racine	1639–99	France	Playwright	<i>Phèdre</i> [1677]
Jonathan Swift	1667–1745	Ireland	Novelist/ essayist	<i>Gulliver's Travels</i> [1726]
Xueqin Cao	c. 1715–63	China	Novelist	<i>Dream of the Red Chamber</i> [1791]
Johann Wolfgang von Goethe	1749–1832	Germany	Novelist/ playwright	<i>Faust</i> [1808]
William Wordsworth	1770–1850	Britain	Poet	<i>The Prelude</i> [1799]
Jane Austen	1775–1817	Britain	Novelist	<i>Pride and Prejudice</i> [1813]
John Keats	1795–1821	Britain	Poet	<i>Endymion</i> [1818]
Alexander Pushkin	1799–1837	Russia	Poet/ novelist	<i>Eugene Onegin</i> [1828]
Honoré de Balzac	1799–1850	France	Novelist	<i>La Comédie Humaine</i> [1827–47]
Alexandre Dumas	1802–70	France	Novelist	<i>The Three Musketeers</i> [1844]
Victor Hugo	1802–85	France	Novelist	<i>Les Misérables</i> [1862]
Ralph Waldo Emerson	1803–82	US	Essayist/ poet	<i>The Conduct of Life</i> [1860]

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Hans Christian Andersen	1805–75	Denmark	Novelist	<i>Fairy Tales</i> [1835–37]
Henry Longfellow	1807–82	US	Poet	<i>Hiawatha</i> [1855]
Charles Dickens	1812–70	Britain	Novelist	<i>Great Expectations</i> [1860–61]
Ivan Turgenev	1818–83	Russia	Novelist/ playwright	<i>Fathers and Sons</i> [1862]
George Eliot	1819–80	Britain	Novelist	<i>The Mill on the Floss</i> [1860]
Fyodor Dostoyevsky	1821–81	Russia	Novelist	<i>Crime and Punishment</i> [1866]
Walt Whitman	1819–92	US	Poet	<i>Leaves of Grass</i> [1855–89]
Gustave Flaubert	1821–80	France	Novelist	<i>Madame Bovary</i> [1857]
Henrik Ibsen	1828–1906	Norway	Playwright	<i>Peer Gynt</i> [1867]
Leo Tolstoy	1828–1910	Russia	Novelist	<i>War and Peace</i> [1865–69]
Mark Twain	1835–1910	US	Novelist	<i>Huckleberry Finn</i> [1885]
Thomas Hardy	1840–1928	Britain	Novelist	<i>Tess of the d'Urbervilles</i> [1891]
Henry James	1843–1916	US	Novelist	<i>The Bostonians</i> [1886]
August Strindberg	1849–1912	Sweden	Playwright	<i>The Dance of Death</i> [1901]
George Bernard Shaw	1856–1950	Ireland	Playwright	<i>Man and Superman</i> [1903]
Joseph Conrad	1857–1924	Poland	Novelist	<i>Heart of Darkness</i> [1902]
Anton Chekhov	1860–1904	Russia	Playwright	<i>The Cherry Orchard</i> [1904]
Rabindranath Tagore	1861–1941	India	Poet/ playwright	<i>Gitanjali, Song Offerings</i> [1912]
Edith Wharton	1862–1937	US	Novelist	<i>The Age of Innocence</i> [1920]
William Butler Yeats	1865–1939	Ireland	Poet	<i>The Wild Swans at Coole</i> [1917]
Marcel Proust	1871–1922	France	Novelist	<i>Remembrance of Things Past</i> [1912–27]
Robert Frost	1874–1963	US	Poet	<i>Mountain Interval</i> [1916]
Thomas Mann	1875–1955	Gemany	Novelist	<i>Death in Venice</i> [1913]
Hermann Hesse	1877–1962	Germany	Novelist	<i>The Glass Bead Game</i> [1945]
James Joyce	1882–1941	Ireland	Novelist	<i>Ulysses</i> [1922]
Virginia Woolf	1882–1941	Britain	Novelist	<i>Mrs Dalloway</i> [1925]
Franz Kafka	1883–1924	Czech Republic	Novelist	<i>The Metamorphosis</i> [1916]
D.H. Lawrence	1885–1930	Britain	Novelist/ poet	<i>Sons and Lovers</i> [1913]
Ezra Pound	1885–1972	US	Poet	<i>The Cantos</i> [1915–62]
T.S. Eliot	1888–1965	US/Britain	Poet/ playwright	<i>The Waste Land</i> [1922]
Karel Capek	1890–1938	Czech Republic	Playwright	<i>R.U.R.</i> [1920]
Boris Pasternak	1890–1960	Russia	Novelist	<i>Doctor Zhivago</i> [1957]
Mikhail Bulgakov	1891–1940	Russia	Novelist	<i>The Master and Margarita</i> [1928]
William Faulkner	1897–1962	US	Novelist	<i>The Sound and the Fury</i> [1929]
Bertolt Brecht	1898–1956	Germany	Playwright	<i>Mother Courage</i> [1938]
Federico García Lorca	1898–1936	Spain	Playwright	<i>The House of Bernarda Alba</i> [1936]
Ernest Hemingway	1899–1961	US	Novelist	<i>The Old Man and the Sea</i> [1952]
Jorge Luis Borges	1899–1986	Argentina	Novelist	<i>Labyrinths</i> [1953]
Vladimir Nabokov	1899–1977	Russia/US	Novelist	<i>Lolita</i> [1958]
John Steinbeck	1902–68	US	Novelist	<i>The Grapes of Wrath</i> [1939]
George Orwell	1903–50	Britain	Novelist	<i>Nineteen Eighty-Four</i> [1949]
Samuel Beckett	1906–89	Ireland	Playwright/ novelist	<i>Waiting for Godot</i> [1954]

